Project 2: Hidden Meanings
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VDES24178 Visual Design and Computation
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Design statement

The Alice in Wonderland themed AR aims to create a magical gateway connecting reality and the fairy realm, allowing users to personally experience Alice's fantastical journey through AR technology. and explores themes of reality transition, curious adventure, and psychological transformation. These themes are embodied through floating glowing flowers, a dynamically beating pocket watch, and an unbalanced chessboard, signifying Alice's journey from the living forest to the chaotic court using visual metaphors and magical realism tropes. The pocket watch—both a timepiece and a pulsating heart—mirrors Alice's panic through its irregular rhythm, translating emotional tension into tangible AR movement. Glowing flowers drifting toward the user recreate her first encounter with the talking plants, immediately establishing Wonderland's rule-defying logic. Meanwhile, the chessboard tilted between red and white queens visualizes the story's underlying power struggle as an interactive dilemma, inviting the user to step not just into a story, but into Alice’s shifting perspective and emotional state.

Justification of the AR solution

This AR solution transforms book covers from static visual symbols into dynamic designs. When users trigger the AR experience via their mobile devices, the once-static book cover instantly comes to life. These meticulously crafted interactive animations not only perfectly embody the core theme of “leaping from reality into fantasy” from Alice in Wonderland, but also forge a deep emotional connection with the story's world by inviting users to personally participate in this magical initiation ritual. I believe this immersive, pre-emptive experience transforms the purchase from merely acquiring a classic with a known plot into a vote for a uniquely magical journey. This profoundly ignites users' desire to own the book and heightens their anticipation for the reading experience.

Tropes



Metaphor:
- The ornate golden frame symbolizes the boundary between reality and Wonderland, framing the absurd scene of a giant clock and floating roses. It visualizes Wonderland as a fantastical realm glimpsed within the “picture frame” of reality.
- The trembling giant clock symbolizes the chaotic time within Wonderland (like the illogical time at the Mad Hatter's tea party), vividly presenting the concept of “time spiraling out of control.” Simultaneously, the mechanical structure of the pocket watch mirrors the rhythm of a heartbeat, concretizing Alice's initial panic upon entering Wonderland as a visible physiological reaction.

Irony:
- The elegant golden frame contrasts ironically with the absurd scenes within (giant clock, floating rose petals), satirizing the disconnect between reality and Wonderland's surrealism.

Exaggeration:
- The oversized clock and overwhelming rose petals exaggerate Wonderland's fantastical essence, amplifying the visual impact of time distortion and the world's unreality.



Tropes

Metaphor:
- The open book symbolizes the gateway to Wonderland, suggesting interaction with books as the path to the fantastical realm.
- The flower-adorned skull embodies Wonderland's absurd interpretation of life and death. Death is transformed into fantastical aesthetics, blending horror with beauty.
- The pulsating light and shadow of glowing flowers signifies the wonderland itself as a living, conscious organism.

Irony:
- The skull (a symbol of death) is beautified by flowers, creating irony. The contrast between appearance (beautiful blossoms) and essence (death/absurdity) highlights the wonderland's defining trait: the fusion of terror and beauty.

Hyperbole:
- The landscape “bursting forth” from the pages exaggerates the fairy realm's image of “breaking free from textual constraints,” intensifying the space's three-dimensionality and surrealism.
- Chess pieces with distorted proportions amplify the conflict's absurdity and oppressive atmosphere.

Analogy:
- The sequential elements within the book (skulls, flowers, trees, floating objects) mirror Alice's journey through Wonderland, mapping her exploration through bizarre symbols and fantastical landscapes.
- The dynamic equilibrium created by tilting chess pieces during interaction parallels the fluidity of power dynamics within the narrative.

Final Design

I interact in two ways: proximity touch interaction and light tap interaction.
The touch-sensitive buttons are located on the table.

The petals at the top rotate and flutter.





Pulsing, simulating a heartbeat.

Floating

Red interactive petals,
Yellow interactive flowers and hats on the book,
Blue interactive clock,
Green interactive chess pieces, book, and key.



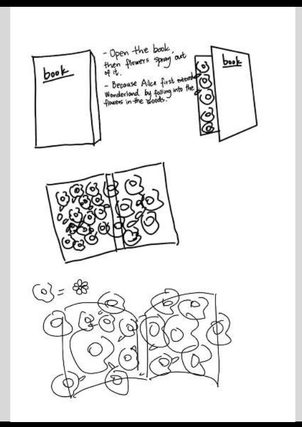
Title: Alice's Adventures in Wonderland
Author: Lewis Carroll
Genre: Fantasy, Children's Literature, Satire

Synopsis of the major themes:

Alice's Adventures in Wonderland tells the surreal journey of a young girl named Alice who impulsively follows a hurried white rabbit down a rabbit hole, plunging into a bizarre and fantastical world. In this upside-down realm governed by absurdity rather than logic, she encounters a series of eccentric characters, including the enigmatic Cheshire Cat, the Mad Hatter, and the tyrannical Queen of Hearts.

Throughout her bewildering adventures, Alice must navigate illogical challenges and shifting rules while grappling with an identity crisis triggered by randomly shrinking and growing after consuming various foods and potions. The novel presents a dazzling dreamscape that uses seemingly nonsensical whimsy to profoundly explore themes of childhood, curiosity, and the uneasy transition into adulthood.

AR Research Project Exercise 1



Concept 1

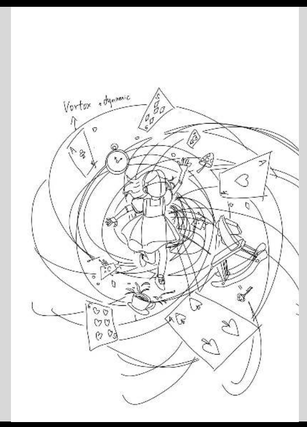
What will you display?:
Present a dynamic book that, when opened, spills forth a cascade of stylized floral symbols from its pages.

What theme from the book are you working with?:
Centered around the “wonderland” theme, this design alludes to Alice's descent into the flowerbed that transports her to Wonderland, capturing the suddenness, fantastical nature, and romanticism of Wonderland's unveiling.

How does this relate to the cover you designed in project 1?:
Similar to the “entrance” concept in Project 1's cover, both designs explore the narrative idea of “entering Wonderland.”

What are you trying to convey with the user?:
Convey to users the unexpectedness and romance of Wonderland's opening. Like Alice stepping into a fantastical world through a “flower encounter,” I aim to let users experience this “unexpected opening of Wonderland” through visuals and potential interactions.

What Visual Trope are you using?:
I aim to employ the visual technique of “flowers bursting forth from the pages of a book.” The dynamic surge of blooms will amplify the narrative tension and fantastical storytelling inherent in the realm's unveiling.



Concept 2

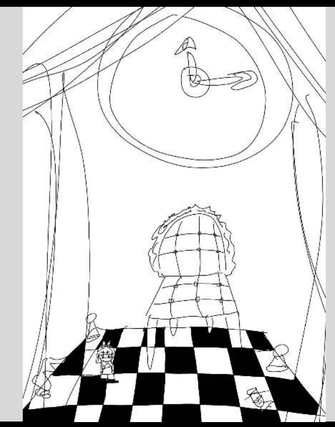
What will you display?:
Alice is depicted at the vortex's center, surrounded by Wonderland elements like playing cards, pocket watches, teacups, rocking horses, and keys, with lines forming a dynamic vortex-like structure.

What theme from the book are you working with?:
Centered on the theme of “the dynamic absurdity of falling into Wonderland,” it captures Alice's sensation of weightlessness and disorientation upon entering Wonderland, along with the surreal adventure enveloped in fantastical elements.

How does this relate to the cover you designed in project 1?:
By depicting the “falling process after entering the portal,” it connects with the cover to form an “entrance - plunge into Wonderland” narrative, enhancing the “sense of motion and absurdity upon entering Wonderland.”

What are you trying to convey with the user?:
By conveying the intense dynamism, absurdity, and overwhelming impact of Wonderland elements as Alice falls, users intuitively experience the immersive sensation of plunging into a fantastical world.

What Visual Trope are you using?:
I aim to employ the dynamic visual technique of a “vortex,” utilizing swirling line structures and disordered element distribution to amplify the kinetic tension and surreal visual impact of the descent.



Concept 3

What will you display?:
A black-and-white checkered chessboard serves as the backdrop, suggesting the exclusive thrones of the Red Queen and White Queen positioned at the board's center. Surrounding them may lie scattered pieces like kings and knights, adorned with gardens of red and white roses (distinguishing factions). Alice stands at the edge of the board as an explorer.

What theme from the book are you working with?:
Centered on the theme of “power struggles and rule-bound absurdity,” the design highlights the Red and White Queens' power conflict within Wonderland, alongside the illogical yet rigid rule system symbolized by the chessboard.

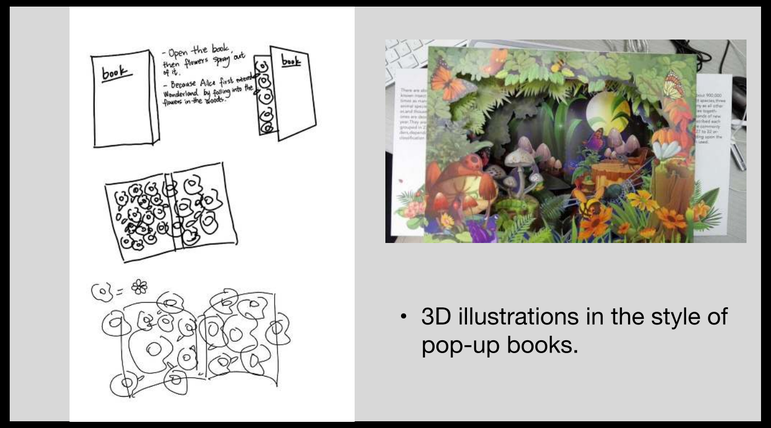
How does this relate to the cover you designed in project 1?:
Building upon Project One's “Red and White Rose Thorns,” this concept expands the exploration dimension after “entering Wonderland,” supplementing the realm's internal power structures and rule-based scenarios while maintaining consistent fantasy aesthetics.

What are you trying to convey with the user?:
I aim to convey that Wonderland isn't merely a realm of adventure, but one where complex power struggles and absurd rules prevail. This allows users to sense the tension between the Red and White Queen's factions and appreciate the multifaceted nature of the Wonderland world.

What Visual Trope are you using?:
Employing a “chessboard” visual approach, the grid-like order of the board and the throne's symbolism of power, paired with the contrasting red/white color scheme, amplify the visual tension and absurdity of the power struggle.

Process work

AR Research Project Exercise 2



- 3D illustrations in the style of pop-up books.

Concept 1

Initial Sketch of concept 1

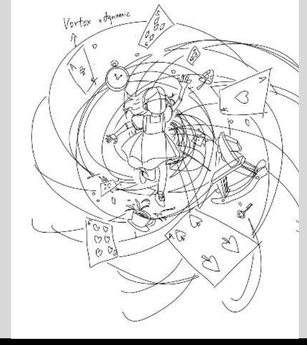
What do you want the user to feel as they explore this experience?
I hope that those who see this AR animation can feel the surprise and immersive fantasy experience when exploring and experiencing it, as if they have instantly stepped into Alice's Wonderland through a book, triggering their curiosity and anticipation for the fairy tale world.

How does the imagery and wording work to create the desired experience?
From the closed book to the flowers that emerge when opened, I hope to create a strong visual contrast of "from reality (the book) to fantasy (the sea of flowers)", simulating the momentary impact of "entering a fairyland".

Are there any other ways of achieving the experience?
Add sound effects, such as the gentle sound of pages turning and flowers blooming, to enhance the sense of surprise through multiple senses. and the fairy tale book was opened, and then flowers sprayed out of it.

What is your Art Direction, what will this look like, simple outlines, text only, photography, detailed illustration?
3D modeling and some illustrations may be adopted.

Are there any existing examples you can provide of the Art Direction to indicate the finished look?
For instance, 3D illustrations in the style of pop-up books.



Concept 2

Initial Sketch of concept 2

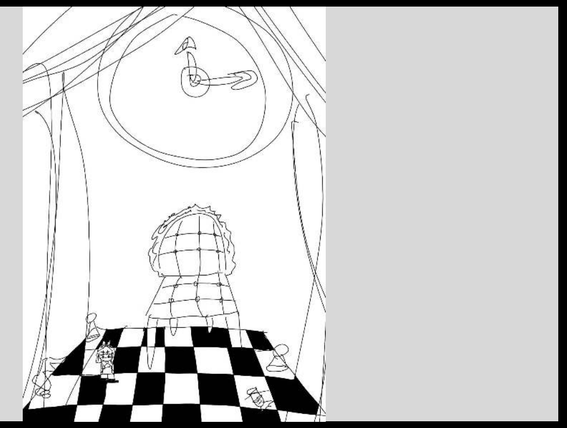
What do you want the user to feel as they explore this experience?
It is hoped that those who watch this AR animation can feel the strong sense of movement, the fantastic weightlessness and the desire to explore, as if they have fallen into wonderland together with Alice, experiencing that chaotic and unknown adventure tension.

How does the imagery and wording work to create the desired experience?
I hope the "vortex" behind can come alive and generate that kind of exploration experience in the interaction.

Are there any other ways of achieving the experience?
Add environmental sound effects, such as the abnormal ticking of a Vortex.

What is your Art Direction, what will this look like, simple outlines, text only, photography, detailed illustration?
Use flat illustrations and partial modeling.

Are there any existing examples you can provide of the Art Direction to indicate the finished look?
Refer to the style of the movie "Alice in Wonderland"



Concept 3

Initial Sketch of concept 3

What do you want the user to feel as they explore this experience?
I hope to present that sense of immersion in exploring mysterious Spaces and the solemnity of a fairy tale.

How does the imagery and wording work to create the desired experience?
A "ritualistic space" was constructed through photo frames, hanging and swaying clocks, playing card elements, and a chessboard floor.

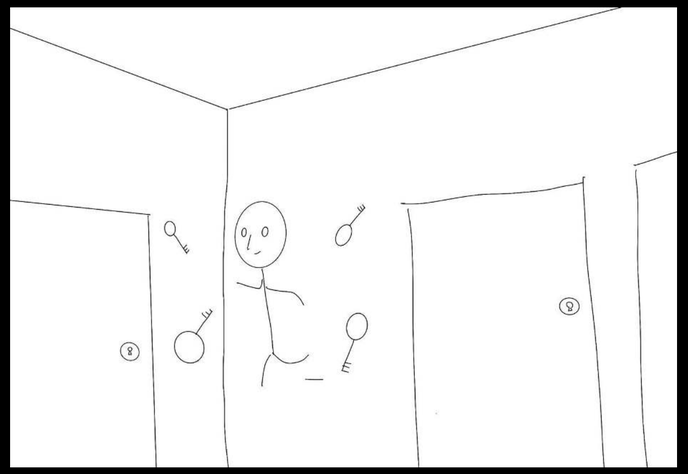
Are there any other ways of achieving the experience?
Add environmental sound effects, such as the abnormal ticking of a clock.

What is your Art Direction, what will this look like, simple outlines, text only, photography, detailed illustration?
I might adopt a 3D art style that combines realism and abstraction. Create realistic 3D models for the spatial structure (photo frames, floors), and make illustrations for elements such as the background and clock.

Are there any existing examples you can provide of the Art Direction to indicate the finished look?
Reference images quickly generated using ai painting tools.

Process work

AR Research Project Exercise 2



Concept 4



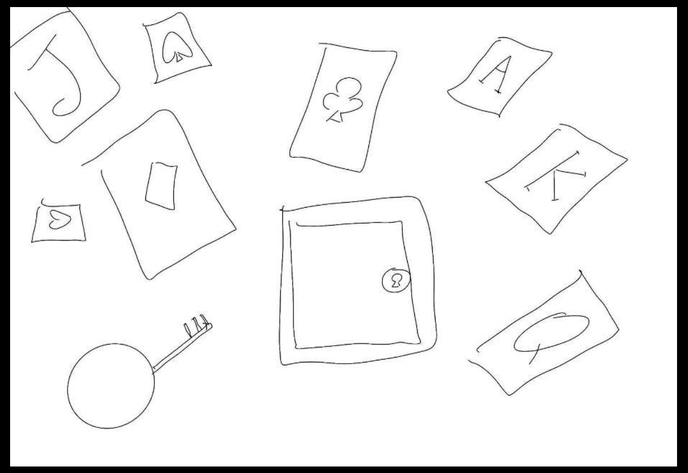
Concept 5



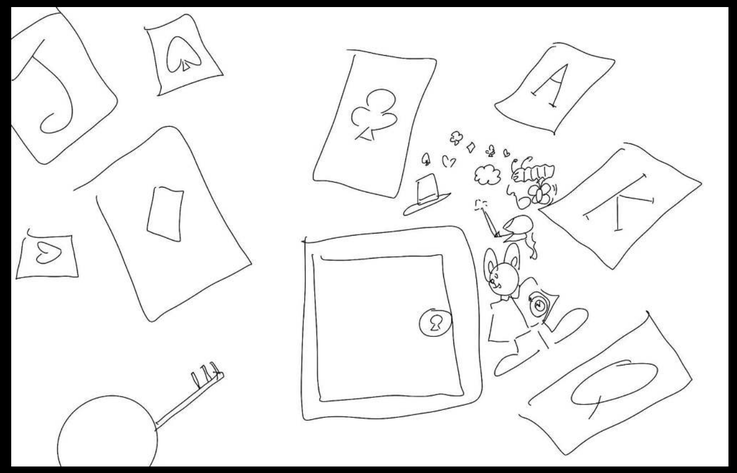
Concept 6

Process work

AR Research Project Exercise 2



Concept 7



Concept 8



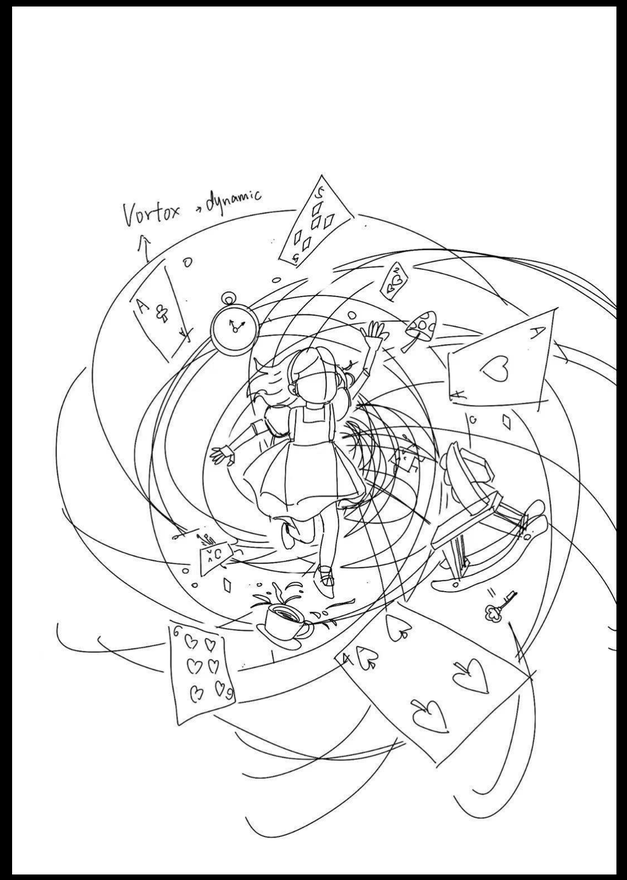
Concept 9

Process work

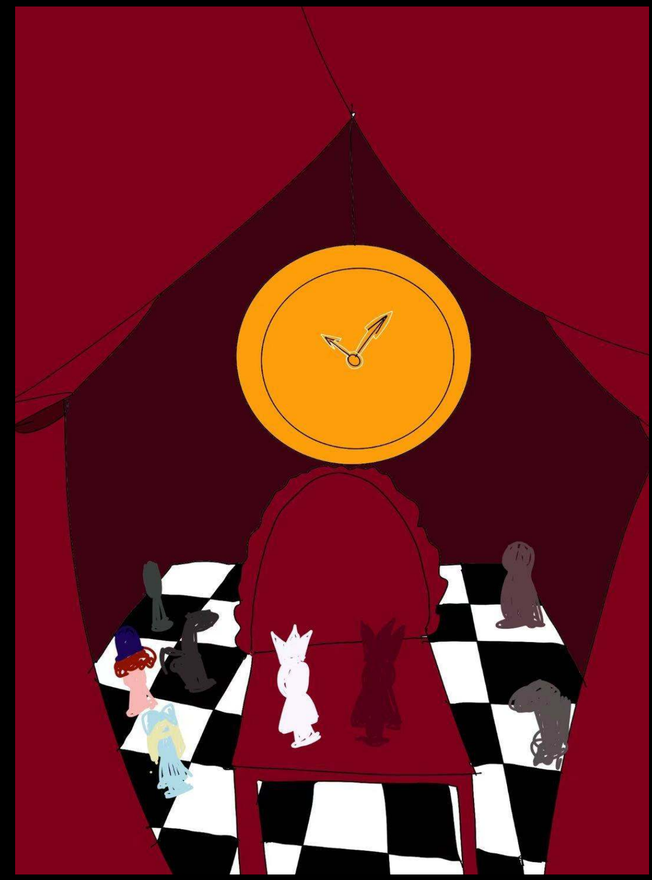
AR Research Project Exercise 2



Concept 1-2



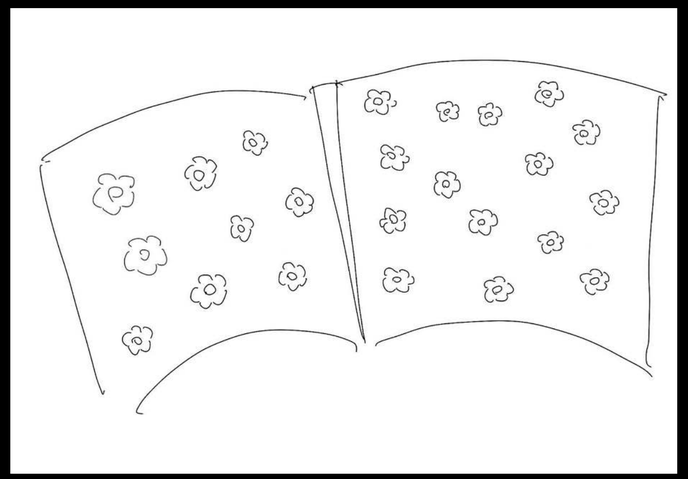
Concept 2



Concept 3-2

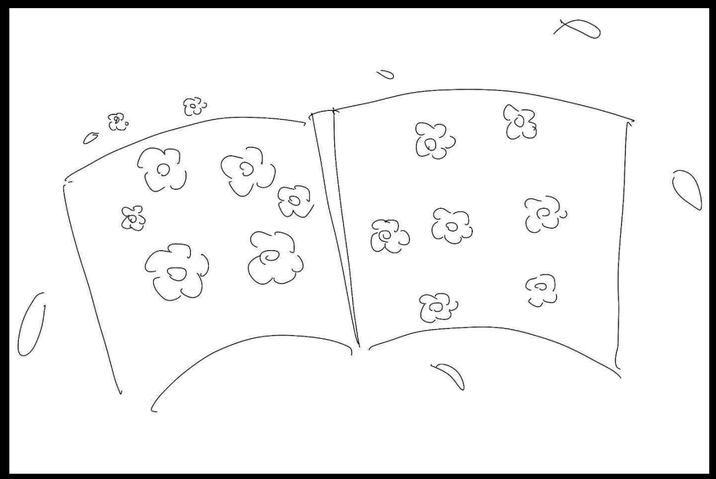
Process work

Storyboarding exercise 1



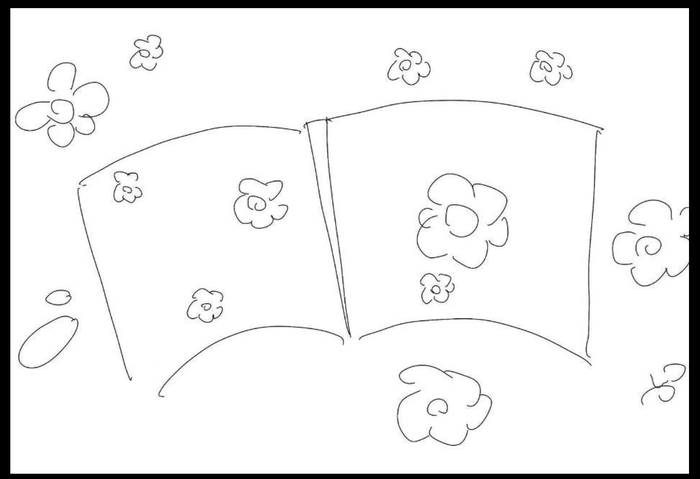
Screen 1 - Description

- A book lies open at the center of the scene, its pages covered in simple floral sketches, surrounded by nothingness.
- As the user slowly approaches the device, the flowers begin to float.
- The book conveys the disorientation of first entering the “wonderland,” hinting at its mystique.



Screen 2 - Description

- Above the book, several petals slowly “drift out” from the pages, remaining suspended. In the corner, a pocket watch floats with a rhythmic tremor.
- As the user continues to approach, focus shifts to the petals and watch. The petals accelerate their drift, while the watch intensifies its trembling.
- The “unrealistic floating petals and trembling pocket watch” hint at the fantastical nature of the book's world, revealing only “abnormalities in time and natural elements.”

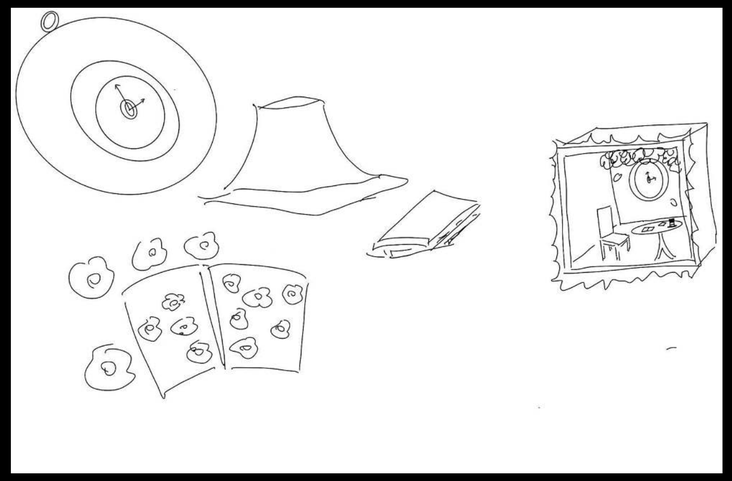


Screen 3 - Description

- Petals scatter wildly, swirling around the “user” as their center point.
- The user reaches out or approaches the hat/book.
- The book remains stationary while select flowers float.
- The blooming flowers make the user aware of this “fantasy world.”

Process work

Storyboarding exercise 1



Screen 4 - Description

- The pocket watch, hat, and petals dynamically hover around the book. Combined with background music and select audio effects, an immersive atmosphere is created.
- The user maintains interaction (like tapping controls, continuing to approach).
- All elements form a cyclical animation: petals rotate around the book, the pocket watch periodically shakes, and the hat rises and falls.
- While establishing a clear theme, the design maintains the suspense of a “fairy-tale adventure,” hinting to the user, “This is Alice's fantastical gateway,” and sparking their desire to explore.

Process work

Sources cited

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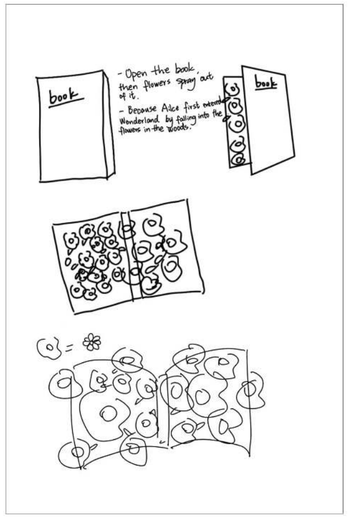
Appendix

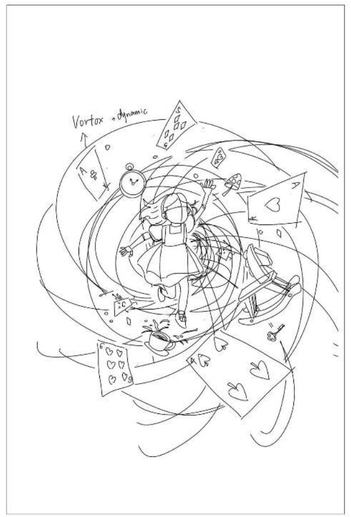
Visual Design **& Computation**

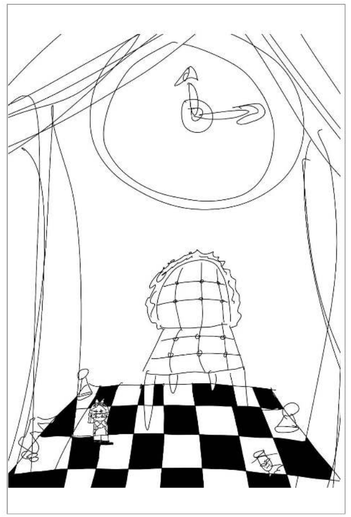
Week **7**

Activity **AR Research Project Exercise 2**

Instructions
Explore what you want the user to feel from your three initial sketches







Initial Sketch of concept 1

What do you want the user to feel as they explore this experience?

I hope that those who see this AR animation can feel the surprise and immersive fantasy experience when exploring and experiencing it, as if they have instantly stepped into Alice's Wonderland through a book, triggering their curiosity and anticipation for the fairy tale world.

How does the imagery and wording work to create the desired experience?

From the closed book to the flowers that emerge when opened, I hope to create a strong visual contrast of "from reality (the book) to fantasy (the sea of flowers)", simulating the momentary impact of "entering a fairyland".

Are there any other ways of achieving the experience?

Add sound effects, such as the gentle sound of pages turning and flowers blooming, to enhance the sense of surprise through multiple senses.

The fairy tale book was opened, and then flowers sprayed out of it.

What is your Art Direction, what will this look like, simple outlines, text only, photography, detailed illustration?

3D modeling and some illustrations may be adopted.

Are there any existing examples you can provide of the Art Direction to indicate the finished look?

For instance, 3D illustrations in the style of pop-up books



Reference images quickly generated using ai painting tools



Initial Sketch of concept 2

What do you want the user to feel as they explore this experience?

It is hoped that those who watch this AR animation can feel the strong sense of movement, the fantastic weightlessness and the desire to explore, as if they have fallen into wonderland together with Alice, experiencing that chaotic and unknown adventure tension.

How does the imagery and wording work to create the desired experience?

I hope the "vortex" behind can come alive and generate that kind of exploration experience in the interaction.

This is what I hope the vortex behind will stir up, creating that sense of a passage, just like Alice's passage from reality to Wonderland.

Are there any other ways of achieving the experience?

Add environmental sound effects, such as the abnormal ticking of a Vortex

What is your Art Direction, what will this look like, simple outlines, text only, photography, detailed illustration?

Use flat illustrations and partial modelling

Are there any existing examples you can provide of the Art Direction to indicate the finished look?

Refer to the style of the movie "Alice in Wonderland"

Reference images quickly generated using ai painting tools



Initial Sketch of concept 3

What do you want the user to feel as they explore this experience?

I hope to present that sense of immersion in exploring mysterious Spaces and the solemnity of a fairy tale.

How does the imagery and wording work to create the desired experience? A "ritualistic space" was constructed through photo frames, hanging and swaying clocks, playing card elements, and a chessboard floor.

I hope the clock at the back will move. Then the overall picture might be a bit dark. If I have extra time, I hope to have that kind of hand bone to climb onto the throne. Just like the tyranny of the Red Queen.

Are there any other ways of achieving the experience?

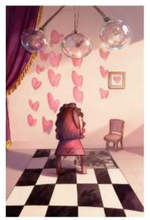
Add environmental sound effects, such as the abnormal ticking of a clock

What is your Art Direction, what will this look like, simple outlines, text only, photography, detailed illustration?

I might adopt a 3D art style that combines realism and abstraction. Create realistic 3D models for the spatial structure (photo frames, floors), and make illustrations for elements such as the background and clock.

Are there any existing examples you can provide of the Art Direction to indicate the finished look?

Reference images quickly generated using ai painting tools

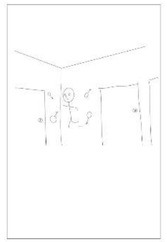


Visual Design **& Computation**

Week **7**

Activity **Go Further**

Instructions
Choose the best idea from the previous exercise and make an abundance of alternative ideas.
Think about characters, themes, content, the world in which it is set - how can you explore these in AR?

















Appendix

Visual Design **& Computation**

Week **6**

Activity **Book Research Project Exercise**

Instructions
Answer the questions below to explore themes for the AR part of the book cover:



Place your finished book cover above

Title: **Alice's Adventures in Wonderland**

Author: **Lewis Carroll**

Genre: Fantasy, Children's Literature, Satire

Synopsis of the themes:
Alice's Adventures in Wonderland tells the surreal journey of a young girl named Alice who impulsively follows a hurried white rabbit down a rabbit hole, plunging into a bizarre and fantastical world. In this upside-down realm governed by absurdity rather than logic, she encounters a series of eccentric characters, including the enigmatic Cheshire Cat, the Mad Hatter, and the tyrannical Queen of Hearts.
Throughout her bewildering adventures, Alice must navigate illogical challenges and shifting rules while grappling with an identity crisis triggered by randomly shrinking and growing after consuming various foods and potions. The novel presents a dazzling dreamscape that uses seemingly nonsensical whimsy to profoundly explore themes of childhood, curiosity, and the uneasy transition into adulthood.

Concept 1

What will you display?:
Present a dynamic book that, when opened, spills forth a cascade of stylized floral symbols from its pages.

What theme from the book are you working with?:
Centered around the "wonderland" theme, this design alludes to Alice's descent into the flowerbed that transports her to Wonderland, capturing the suddenness, fantastical nature, and romanticism of Wonderland's unveiling.

How does this relate to the cover you designed in project 1?:
Similar to the "entrance" concept in Project 1's cover, both designs explore the narrative idea of "entering Wonderland."

What are you trying to convey with the user?:
Convey to users the unexpectedness and romance of Wonderland's opening. Like Alice stepping into a fantastical world through a "flower encounter," I aim to let users experience this "unexpected opening of Wonderland" through visuals and potential interactions.

What Visual Trope are you using?:
I aim to employ the visual technique of "flowers bursting forth from the pages of a book." The dynamic surge of blooms will amplify the narrative tension and fantastical storytelling inherent in the realm's unveiling.

Concept 2

What will you display?:
Alice is depicted at the vortex's center, surrounded by Wonderland elements like playing cards, pocket watches, teacups, rocking horses, and keys, with lines forming a dynamic vortex-like structure.

What theme from the book are you working with?:
Centered on the theme of "the dynamic absurdity of falling into Wonderland," it captures Alice's sensation of weightlessness and disorientation upon entering Wonderland, along with the surreal adventure enveloped in fantastical elements.

How does this relate to the cover you designed in project 1?:
By depicting the "falling process after entering the portal," it connects with the cover to form an "entrance - plunge into Wonderland" narrative, enhancing the "sense of motion and absurdity upon entering Wonderland."

What are you trying to convey with the user?:
By conveying the intense dynamism, absurdity, and overwhelming impact of Wonderland elements as Alice falls, users intuitively experience the immersive sensation of plunging into a fantastical world.

What Visual Trope are you using?:
I aim to employ the dynamic visual technique of a "vortex," utilizing swirling line structures and disordered element distribution to amplify the kinetic tension and surreal visual impact of the descent.

Concept 3

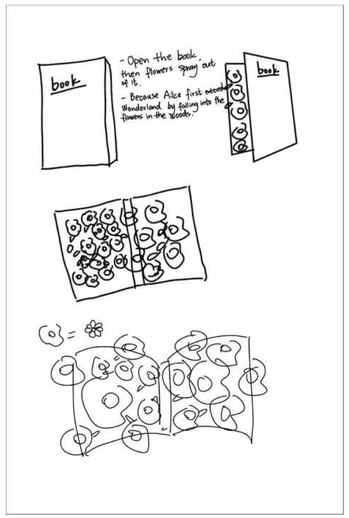
What will you display?:
A black-and-white checkered chessboard serves as the backdrop, suggesting the exclusive thrones of the Red Queen and White Queen positioned at the board's center. Surrounding them may lie scattered pieces like kings and knights, adorned with gardens of red and white roses (distinguishing factions). Alice stands at the edge of the board as an explorer.

What theme from the book are you working with?:
Centered on the theme of "power struggles and rule-bound absurdity," the design highlights the Red and White Queens' power conflict within Wonderland, alongside the illogical yet rigid rule system symbolized by the chessboard.

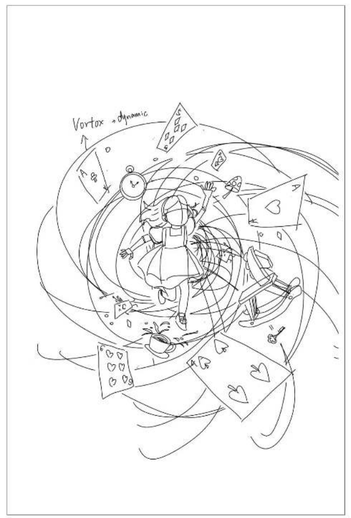
How does this relate to the cover you designed in project 1?:
Building upon Project One's "Red and White Rose Thorns," this concept expands the exploration dimension after "entering Wonderland," supplementing the realm's internal power structures and rule-based scenarios while maintaining consistent fantasy aesthetics.

What are you trying to convey with the user?:
I aim to convey that Wonderland isn't merely a realm of adventure, but one where complex power struggles and absurd rules prevail. This allows users to sense the tension between the Red and White Queen's factions and appreciate the multifaceted nature of the Wonderland world.

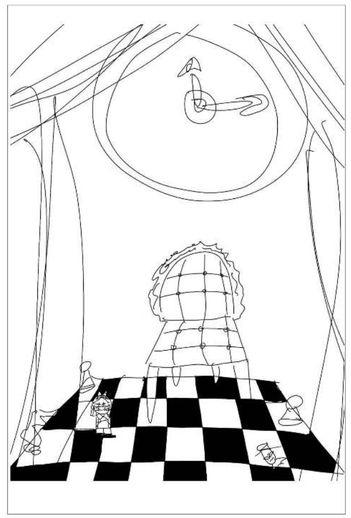
What Visual Trope are you using?:
Employing a "chessboard" visual approach, the grid-like order of the board and the throne's symbolism of power, paired with the contrasting red/white color scheme, amplify the visual tension and absurdity of the power struggle.



Initial Sketch of concept 1



Initial Sketch of concept 2



Initial Sketch of concept 3

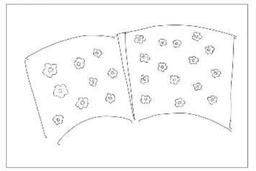
Visual Design **& Computation**

Week **11**

Activity **Storyboard**

Instructions
Complete a short storyboard to show the user might interact or the project animate.
Do you want this to make the user curious? How will you achieve that? How much of the book narrative might you give away?
Is this about driving curiosity or about informing the user? How will the user interact and with what? How will it be animated?

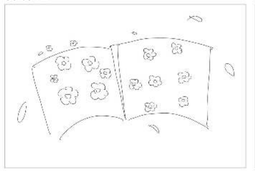
Screen **1**



Description

A book lies open at the center of the scene, its pages covered in simple floral sketches, surrounded by nothingness.
As the user slowly approaches the device, the flowers begin to float.
The book conveys the disorientation of first entering the "wonderland," hinting at its mystique.

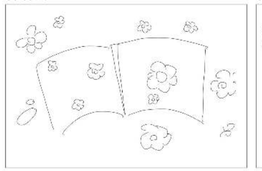
Screen **2**



Description

Above the book, several petals slowly "drift out" from the pages, remaining suspended. In the corner, a pocket watch floats with a rhythmic tremor.
As the user continues to approach, focus shifts to the petals and watch. The petals accelerate their drift, while the watch intensifies its trembling.
The "unrealistic floating petals and trembling pocket watch" hint at the fantastical nature of the book's world, revealing only "abnormalities in time and natural elements."

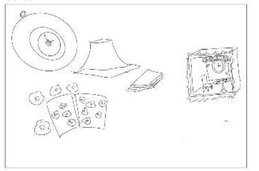
Screen **3**



Description

Petals scatter wildly, swirling around the "user" as their center point.
The user reaches out or approaches the hat/book.
The book remains stationary while select flowers float.
The blooming flowers make the user aware of this "fantasy world."

Screen **4**



Description

The pocket watch, hat, and petals dynamically hover around the book. Combined with background music and select audio effects, an immersive atmosphere is created.
The user maintains interaction (like tapping controls, continuing to approach).
All elements form a cyclical animation: petals rotate around the book, the pocket watch periodically shakes, and the hat rises and falls.
While establishing a clear theme, the design maintains the suspense of a "fairy-tale adventure," hinting to the user, "This is Alice's fantastical gateway," and sparking their desire to explore.

THANK YOU